

Alation Data Catalog

Ad Platforms Data Governance

Why This Program and Alation Matter to Leadership

BUSINESS OUTCOMES

High-value business outcomes

What leadership gains.

- **Reduced regulatory and audit risk across GDPR and SOX** through improved visibility into PII, financial, and sensitive data.
- Faster, more **defensible decisions** backed by trusted definitions, lineage, and ownership.
- Operational efficiency — fewer duplicate efforts, less manual validation and reconciliation.
- **Scalable foundation for AI**, automation, and advanced analytics across the enterprise.
- Improved visibility into **PII and user consent signals** across systems and platforms.

WHY NOW

Audit-driven urgency

Findings from the 2024 EY audit.

- Difficulty identifying **where PII resides** across multiple systems and platforms.
- **Ungoverned and fragmented sources** discovered to contain sensitive personal data.
- Triggered formal **risk assessment and ongoing remediation** work.
- Highlighted gaps in lineage, ownership, and documentation that must be closed.

PROGRAM & ALATION IMPACT

How we deliver the outcomes

Program + platform working together.

- **Centralized system of record** for data assets — Alation as the catalog of truth.
- Improved visibility into assets, lineage, and ownership across domains.
- Stronger stewardship, accountability, and governance consistency.
- Direct alignment with **regulatory and compliance obligations**.
- **Lower long-term operational and compliance risk** for the enterprise.
- Scalable, enterprise-wide governance capability that grows with the business.

Data governance, enabled by a scalable catalog like Alation, is a critical capability for managing risk, enabling growth, and supporting trusted decision-making across the business.

What a Data Catalog Is and How It Supports Data Governance

Two sides of the same story: business pressure for answers, and the inspectable metadata layer that backs them.

WHAT A DATA CATALOG IS (GOVERNANCE LENS)

System of record

Technical inventory plus business meaning: objects, definitions, ownership signals, policies where recorded.

Inspectable lineage

Makes lineage and relationships inspectable so impact analysis and data-flow narratives are grounded in metadata, not folklore.

Business-to-physical alignment

Central place to align business terms to physical fields — reduces mismatches between reporting language and source semantics.

Reusable, not re-copied

When wired to BI, APIs, and MCP, the same descriptions are reused instead of re-pasted into wikis and tickets.

WHY AD PLATFORMS GOVERNANCE

1

Defensible answers, fast

Leaders need to know what data exists, what it means, who owns it, and how it flows — without multi-day scavenger hunts.

2

Evidence-based conversations

Concentrates metadata, glossary links, and lineage so privacy, retention, and control discussions start from facts, not folklore.

3

Risk reduction

Stronger documentation and usage signals reduce wrong interpretations of metrics and PII — lowering operational and compliance risk.

4

Stewardship sets the ceiling

Mature stewardship + integrations scale the model; empty pages and thin lineage limit how much the platform can credibly support.

What Alation Provides — and the Ad Platform Governance Outcomes it Supports

Centralized metadata capabilities in our tenant, mapped to the governance outcomes stewards are accountable for.

OUR STACK (ALATION)



Metadata ingestion & search

Across connected data and BI sources — depth and freshness depend on connectors and schedules.



Glossaries & articles

Stewardship patterns; optional workflows / approvals where teams have configured them.



Lineage visualization

Where platform signals and connectors support it — coverage is not uniform across every hop.



Automated access (API / MCP)

So assessments and tools can pull the same catalog fields users see in the UI.

GOVERNANCE OUTCOMES



Privacy & classification

Inventory and field-level documentation support tagging, sensitivity review, and scope for assessments.



SOX / financial reporting

Clearer metric definitions and lineage narratives for controls-heavy reporting (stewardship quality matters).



Retention & lifecycle

Knowing where datasets live aligns policy discussion to real systems; enforcement remains platform-specific.



Ownership & lineage

Explicit stewards and paths reduce orphaned assets and ambiguous transformations — when maintained.

Current-State Value & Alation Footprint (Across DEEPT)

What teams get now from the catalog — plus why breadth of connections only matters when curation and lineage keep pace.

Srikanth and Paul to provide additional metrics slide



Centralized data discovery across Ads ecosystem

Schemas, tables, columns, and glossary links — less repeat questioning across chat and email. ((e.g., curated Ads glossaries: DA, DAAPI, Audience360, AVOD)



Faster impact analysis through lineage visibility

Lineage and dependency views (where populated) shorten impact analysis for upstream changes and broken downstream reports. ((e.g., Snowflake UNIVERSE360.ADVERTISING schemas,)



Routes questions to owners

Documented ownership and stewardship fields route questions to accountable teams when those fields are kept current.



Reuse via API / MCP

Repeatable metadata reuse for reviews and engineering workflows where security has approved access. (e.g., used in Cursor-based analysis workflows)

*Metrics are of 6/5/26

Wide

Connected data sources

Snowflake, Databricks, Oracle, ODS, STAQ, Athena, operational DBs

Multi

BI sources catalogued

MicroStrategy, Tableau, and domain workspaces

5,000+

Glossary terms

Across multiple domain glossaries (Aug 2025 overview)

Authoritative

Source list lives in Alation

Curation depth + lineage scale the value, not just connections

Alation Usage & Stewardship Adoption (Across DEEPT)

Stewardship metrics show where to invest; engagement shows the catalog is in daily workflow.



Primary stewardship view

Alation's Curation Metric Report — track documentation completeness and lineage-related coverage by source.



Governance use

Metrics used to prioritize backlog (which systems are thinly described), justify connector work, and show progress to sponsors.



Interpret with care

These metrics should be read as directional indicators, interpreted with stewards and tooling context — not treated as a single governance health score.

*Metrics are of 6/5/26

~500

Avg monthly users

Sustained reliance on the catalog for discovery and reference

~7,200

Avg page views / month

Repeated access to object pages, lineage, and glossary content

~7,500

Avg searches / month

Search is the primary front door — title/description quality matters

~25

Avg query executions

SQL or query activity launched from catalog contexts (where tracked)

Please see Appendix for additional details

AI-Enabled Use Cases with Alation and Cursor MCP

AI-driven use cases that accelerate data discovery, improve decision-making, and enable scalable governance across Disney Ad Platforms.

1 AI-Assisted Data Discovery

Find trusted data in minutes using natural-language search across the catalog.

2 Automated Impact Analysis

Predict downstream impact of schema and definition changes before release.

3 Audit & Compliance Reporting

Generate consistent, defensible PII, SOX, and GDPR evidence packs on demand.

4 Personal Data / PII Assessments

Identify PII fields, classifications, and gaps to accelerate audit remediation.

5 Field-Class Definition Standardization

Standardize column definitions and inherit them automatically from source to BI.

6 Metadata Enrichment & Documentation

AI-drafted descriptions, glossary links, and stewards — approved by humans, applied at scale.



Note: Alation metadata is accessed via an internal Cursor MCP integration for read-only analysis, with restricted admin-controlled write access. This is separate from Alation's vendor MCP.

Data Governance Tools and Capabilities in Development

All tools developed or in development by Srikanth Gurram

AI-driven tools being developed and deployed on Alation, built using Cursor and MCP to improve visibility, reduce risk, and scale governance.

1

Data Lineage Finder Tool

Technology: Alation + React JS & Fast API

Production

What it does: Dynamically surfaces upstream and downstream lineage using catalog metadata and MCP.

Impact: Accelerates impact analysis, change management, and incident triage.

2

Alation Curation Dashboard

Technology: Alation + MicroStrategy

Production

What it does: Provides visibility into the completeness of Alation descriptions at the schema and column level.

Impact: Accelerates metadata curation at scale while ensuring human oversight and approval.

3

Data Privacy / PII Detection Tool

Technology: Alation + React JS & Fast API + LLM

Production

What it does: Uses Alation metadata via MCP to identify and flag sensitive or personal data across datasets.

Impact: Supports audit response, compliance posture, and proactive risk reduction.

4

Alation Data Dictionary Transfer Tool

Technology: Alation + React JS & Fast API

In Development

What it does: Automatically copies and applies data definitions across systems, schemas, and tables (e.g. copies definition for ad_id from table A to table B)

Impact: Eliminates repetitive manual work while ensuring consistent business definitions across systems improving data quality.

AI-enabled tooling on top of trusted metadata is transforming governance from manual processes into scalable, intelligent systems.

Scaling Data Governance: Foundation to Enterprise (FY26–FY28)

Scaling data governance through Alation, from foundational catalog to enterprise-scale, AI-enabled metadata platform.

NOW (FY26)

Alation Catalog Foundation

Foundation in place • Buy vs Build decision

- **Alation established** as system of record for priority Ad Platforms data
- **Priority sources onboarded** — Snowflake, Databricks, Oracle, ODS, and BI ecosystems
- **PII classification** and sensitivity tagging in place on critical assets
- **Initial lineage and dictionaries** curated across top-tier domains
- **Stewardship model** and ownership assigned for priority assets

CURRENT (FY27)

Scaling Alation Coverage & Integrations

In progress • Alation contract renewal (2027)

- Expand **data source onboarding** across the Ads data ecosystem, including virtual sources
- Scale **lineage coverage and accuracy** across priority Ad Platforms domains
- Improve **glossary and data dictionaries** with active steward SLAs
- Enable **AI-assisted enrichment** for metadata, documentation, and definitions
- Enable **API and MCP access** for Cursor and downstream AI tooling
- Track governance metrics; prepare Alation contract renewal (2027)
- **Buy vs Build decision** completed for the enterprise data catalog*

FUTURE (FY28)

Enterprise-scale, AI-enabled Governance

Scale & maturity • Enterprise governance maturity

- **Enterprise-scale governance** anchored on Alation across Ad Platforms
- **Consistent lineage and definitions** across Ad event data and downstream reporting
- **AI-assisted curation at scale** — definition inheritance and auto-enrichment
- **Coverage and time-to-answer** metrics meeting enterprise governance targets
- **Trusted, scalable data foundation** enabling faster decisions and reduced risk
- **Reusable metadata** fueling analytics, AI, and audit readiness

Appendix

Cursor–Alation MCP Use Case — AI-Assisted Data Discovery

Plain-English questions over the Ad Platforms catalog return trusted assets in minutes — eliminating tribal-knowledge bottlenecks.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Days → Mins

Time to trusted data

All Domains

Discovery scope

Certified-first

Search results prioritize

New analysts

Onboarding accelerated

THE CHALLENGE

Ad Platforms analysts lose hours searching across systems to locate the right Snowflake, Databricks, etc. table or BI report for ad event data — onboarding takes weeks.

Tribal knowledge of raw_beacon, AGG_GATEWAY_ADS, and UNIVERSE360.ADVERTISING slows decisions and risks using the wrong source.

AI-ASSISTED WORKFLOW

- 1 Natural-Language Query**
Analyst asks Cursor (e.g., "where is Hulu off-platform impression data?") via MCP.
- 2 Catalog Resolution**
MCP queries Alation glossary, tables, columns, and lineage for matches.
- 3 Trust Signals**
Surface ownership, freshness, classification, certification for each match.
- 4 Guided Handoff**
Cursor returns curated assets + sample queries; links open in Alation.

KEY FINDINGS

Onboarding accelerated

New analysts reach productive analysis in days vs. weeks — fewer back-and-forths, fewer wrong-table mistakes.

Highest-trust assets surface first

Certified, owned, recently-refreshed assets are prioritized — reducing risk of building on stale sources.

REUSABLE TEMPLATE — AI-ASSISTED DATA DISCOVERY

Step 1

Ask

Pose a plain-English data question via Cursor MCP.

Step 2

Match

MCP queries Alation catalog, glossary, lineage.

Step 3

Rank

Surface trust signals — ownership, freshness, certification.

Step 4

Use

Hand off curated assets and sample queries; open in Alation.

Cursor–Alation MCP Use Case — Automated Impact Analysis

Predict the downstream impact of schema and definition changes across Ad Platforms pipelines, BI, and 3P consumers — before code goes out.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Days → Hrs

Time to impact brief

100+

Downstream dependencies traced

Pre-release

Issues caught earlier

All Domains

Lineage coverage

THE CHALLENGE

A schema or definition change in Snowflake ODS ad event tables (raw_beacon, AGG_GATEWAY_ADS views) can silently break BI dashboards and 3P feeds.

Manual impact analysis is slow and partial — easy to miss downstream systems such as DCM dashboards, STAQ feeds, and Linear BI until production breaks.

AI-ASSISTED WORKFLOW

- 1 Define Change Scope**
Engineer supplies the changed asset (e.g., UNIVERSE360.ADVERTISING.AGG_GATEWAY_ADS).
- 2 Lineage Trace via MCP**
MCP walks Alation lineage both upstream and downstream of the changed asset.
- 3 Consumer Inventory**
Identify affected dashboards, reports, scheduled jobs, 3P feeds, and stewards.
- 4 Impact Brief**
Generate a stakeholder-ready brief with affected assets, owners, and risk.

KEY FINDINGS

Hidden consumers surfaced

Downstream assets such as DCM dashboards, STAQ feeds, and Linear BI routinely missed by manual reviews are flagged before release.

Owners notified pre-deploy

Stewards and SMEs identified up front — change socialized before code, reducing rework and outages.

REUSABLE TEMPLATE — IMPACT ANALYSIS

Step 1

Scope

Identify the changed table, column, or definition.

Step 2

Trace

Pull upstream + downstream lineage via Alation MCP.

Step 3

Map

List downstream consumers, owners, dependent jobs.

Step 4

Brief

Generate the change-impact summary with action items.

Cursor–Alation MCP Use Case — Audit & Compliance Reporting

Repeatable, defensible evidence packs for PII, SOX, and GDPR cycles — generated directly from Ad Platforms catalog metadata.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Days → Hrs

Time to evidence pack

100+

Controls evidenced

PII · SOX · GDPR

Frameworks supported

Repeatable

Consistent every cycle

THE CHALLENGE

Audit cycles (EY findings, SOX walkthroughs, GDPR DSARs) force stewards to manually assemble audit evidence across Snowflake, Databricks, Oracle, ODS, and BI (e.g., identifying where PII exists, who owns it, and how it is used). This process is slow and error-prone. Outputs vary between cycles and reviewers, eroding auditor confidence and making remediation tracking difficult.

AI-ASSISTED WORKFLOW

- 1 Define Audit Scope**
Auditor / steward defines framework (PII, SOX, GDPR) and in-scope domains.
- 2 Catalog Posture Pull**
MCP queries Alation for classifications, ownership, lineage, freshness across scope.
- 3 Map Metadata to Controls**
Cross-reference Alation fields to audit controls (PII, ownership, retention).
- 4 Generate Evidence Pack**
Produce a consistent, repeatable export — same shape every cycle.

KEY FINDINGS

Audit drift eliminated

Same data, same format, same controls each cycle — auditor confidence improves and review time drops.

Gaps surface pre-audit

Unmanaged sources, missing owners, and untagged PII fields are identified early — remediated before review.

REUSABLE TEMPLATE — AUDIT EVIDENCE PACK

Step 1

Scope

Define audit framework and asset universe.

Step 2

Pull

Query Alation catalog posture via MCP.

Step 3

Map

Match metadata fields to audit controls.

Step 4

Pack

Generate the repeatable, defensible evidence export.

Cursor–Alation MCP Use Case: Personal Data Assessment (STAQ)

How AI-assisted catalog analysis turned a multi-day Legal compliance request into a same-session deliverable — with business validation and remediation built in.

BUSINESS IMPACT

~4 hrs

Estimated manual effort

< 30 min

Completed with AI

1,100+

Columns audited

3

Data-quality issues found

THE CHALLENGE

Legal requested an assessment of personal data within the STAQ ad data source — 6 schemas, 70+ tables, 1,100+ columns spanning multiple 3P vendor integrations.

Traditionally, a steward inspects Alation, cross-references Confluence, and meets with the business — typically multiple days and meetings.

AI-ASSISTED WORKFLOW

- Automated Catalog Scan**
Queried all schemas, tables, columns via Alation MCP. Checked every column for PII tags.
- Confluence Cross-Reference**
Retrieved DEEPT | STAQ docs and 25 child pages to validate against business context.
- Business Validation**
Compared vendor list with SME — 2 removals and 4 additions identified.
- Remediation Plan**
Drafted executable Alation API change plan with open questions for approval.

KEY FINDINGS

No personal data elements found

Zero columns tagged PII across 1,100+ columns. STAQ holds aggregate 3P ad campaign metrics — not consumer personal data.

Data quality variances identified

Vendor list out of date — 2 inactive (MOAT, Adform), 4 missing (DSPs, SSPs, Taboola, Connatix). Remediation drafted.

REUSABLE TEMPLATE — DATA COMPLIANCE ASSESSMENT

Step 1 Scan

Query Alation MCP for all columns. Check PII / sensitivity custom fields.

Step 2 Validate

Cross-reference Confluence to confirm whether flagged columns represent real PII.

Step 3 Verify

Engage business SME to validate findings and identify quality gaps.

Step 4 Remediate

Draft + execute Alation updates; create Jira ticket for tracking.

Cursor–Alation MCP Use Case — Field-Class Definition Standardization

Standardize what `_id`, `_cd`, `_date`, `_timestamp` mean across Ad Platforms — and inherit those definitions automatically from source to BI.

BUSINESS IMPACT

1000+

Columns standardized

Source → BI

Inheritance path (Definitions flow)

Consistent

Definitions across domains

Reusable

Across teams and tools

THE CHALLENGE

The same column class (`_id`, `_cd`, `_date`, `_timestamp`) appears across tens of thousands of columns in Snowflake, Databricks, Oracle, ODS, BI — defined inconsistently.

Manual curation cannot scale — the same column means different things in different systems, eroding trust and audit defensibility.

AI-ASSISTED WORKFLOW

- Field-Class Scan**
MCP scans Alation for columns matching class suffixes (`_id`, `_cd`, `_date`, `_timestamp`).
- Candidate Definitions**
AI proposes consistent definitions from naming patterns, profiling, and glossary.
- Lineage Inheritance**
Propagate approved definitions through Alation lineage — source → ODS → BI.
- Steward Approval**
Stewards review, edit, or override; approvals push back to Alation.

KEY FINDINGS

Conflicting definitions resolved

Where `_date` or `_id` means different things across domains, conflicts surface for steward alignment.

Curation scales without re-entry

Approved definitions flow downstream automatically — eliminating thousands of repeated manual entries.

REUSABLE TEMPLATE — DEFINITION STANDARDIZATION

Step 1

Scan

Identify class patterns (`_id`, `_cd`, `_date`, `_timestamp`).

Step 2

Propose

AI drafts consistent candidate definitions per class.

Step 3

Inherit

Propagate definitions through lineage via Alation.

Step 4

Approve

Steward review and apply; AI never finalizes alone.

Cursor–Alation MCP Use Case — Metadata Enrichment & Documentation

AI-drafted descriptions, glossary mappings, and steward suggestions — Ad Platforms catalog coverage moves from sporadic to consistent.

BUSINESS IMPACT

1000+

Assets enriched

Days → Mins

Per asset effort

AI-Assisted

Human-approved

Scalable

Across all Ad domains

THE CHALLENGE

Thousands of tables and columns are catalogued but lack descriptions, stewards, or glossary links — limiting search, AI quality, and audit readiness.

Stewards cannot manually enrich at scale — curation backlogs grow and high-impact assets remain under-documented.

AI-ASSISTED WORKFLOW

- 1 Coverage Gap Scan**
MCP identifies undocumented or partial assets in priority Ad domains.
- 2 AI Draft Enrichment**
Generate descriptions, glossary mappings, and steward suggestions from patterns.
- 3 Steward Review**
Stewards approve, edit, or reject AI proposals in a managed queue.
- 4 Push to Alation**
Approved enrichments write back to Alation via API — versioned and auditable.

KEY FINDINGS

Coverage moves from sporadic to consistent

Priority domains reach near-full documentation — improving search, AI quality, and audit defensibility.

Humans stay in control

AI proposes; stewards decide. Every enrichment is reviewed and traceable, with rollback if needed.

REUSABLE TEMPLATE — METADATA ENRICHMENT

Step 1

Scan

Identify undocumented assets in priority domains.

Step 2

Draft

AI proposes descriptions, glossary links, stewards.

Step 3

Review

Steward approval queue with edit and override.

Step 4

Apply

Push approved enrichments to Alation via API.

Data Catalog Strategy: Buy vs Build

Buy (Alation) - Continue with the established catalog platform and expand on it.

● Pros

- Mature, enterprise-proven catalog with active vendor roadmap.
- Faster time to value; existing footprint across Snowflake, Databricks, Oracle, BI, and Ads sources.
- Built-in lineage, glossary, stewardship workflows, search, and API/MCP surfaces.
- Vendor SLAs, security certifications, support, and continued product investment.
- Broad connector library, training, and reference patterns from peer companies.

● Cons

- Recurring license / subscription cost scales with users, sources, and editions.
- Roadmap pace and priorities controlled by vendor; limited override on gaps.
- Customization bounded by product extensibility model and supported APIs.
- Vendor lock-in; migration / exit cost grows as adoption deepens.
- Feature gaps possible for niche Ads / Disney-specific workflows and policies.

Build (Internal) - Invest in internally-developed catalog and governance capabilities.

● Pros

- Full customization for Ads / Disney terminology, controls, and policy nuances.
- Direct control over roadmap, integrations, data contracts, and SLAs.
- Tighter coupling with internal tooling (Cursor, Confluence, MCP, internal LLMs).
- Lower per-user marginal cost at scale once core capabilities are mature.
- Differentiation potential where vendor patterns do not fit the operating model.

● Cons

- Significant engineering investment to reach catalog/lineage/search parity.
- Longer time to value; multi-year delivery and execution risk.
- Ongoing platform, SRE, security, and compliance burden falls internally.
- Talent and retention dependency for specialized metadata / governance skills.
- No vendor-backed certifications, support contracts, or external community.

Alation Socialization Plan

Phased approach to drive alignment, awareness, and adoption of Alation across Ad Platforms

